

JAHANGIRNAGAR UNIVERSITY

DEPARTMENT OF ENGLISH

BA (HONOURS) 4TH YEAR FINAL EXAMINATION QUESTION BANK

COURSE CODE: E 403

COURSE TITLE: Critical and Cultural Theories

Target Stream: Concentration on Applied
Linguistics & ELT

Batches Included: 42, 43, 44, 46, 47, 48, 49, 50 (Batch 45 missing)

CURRENT SYLLABUS REFERENCE & SCOPE (Session: 2021–2022, Batch 51)

CORE CRITICAL & CULTURAL THEORIES:

- **Formalism and New Criticism:** Defamiliarization (Shklovsky); foregrounding (Mayakovsky); practical criticism (Richards); close reading.
- **Structuralism and Semiotics:** Sign & signification (Saussure); paradigm & syntagm; binary oppositions; archetypal criticism (Frye); narratology (Todorov); 'mythology' (Barthes).
- **Reader-Oriented Theories:** Hermeneutics; phenomenology; 'horizon of expectations' (Jauss); reception theory (Iser); speech act theory.
- **Marxist Literary Theory:** Dialectic materialism; base & superstructure; ideology; alienation; commodity fetishism; hegemony (Gramsci); ISA & RSA (Althusser).
- **Feminist Literary Theory:** Androgyny (Woolf); Other (Beauvoir); 'Images of Women' (Millet); gynocriticism (Showalter); l'écriture féminine (Cixous); black feminist criticism (Smith, Lorde); postcolonial feminism (Spivak, Mohanty).
- **Psychoanalytic Criticism:** Oedipal complex; the unconscious; drives & defenses; dream-work; Imaginary, Symbolic and Real (Lacan); trauma.
- **Post-structuralism and Deconstruction:** Logocentrism, différance, and aporia (Derrida); jouissance (Kristeva); death of the author (Barthes); rhizome & deterritorialization (Deleuze); power/knowledge & disciplinary discourse (Foucault).
- **Postmodernism:** Grand narrative (Lyotard); hyperreality & simulacra (Baudrillard); pastiche & late capitalism (Jameson).
- **Postcolonialism:** Othering, diaspora, hybridity, double consciousness, subaltern, mimicry, ambivalence (Bhabha, Spivak).
- **Cultural Theory:** Culture; popular culture; consumption; representation (Hall); cultural materialism.

SECTION A: BROAD ESSAY QUESTIONS (Theoretical Frameworks)

Comprehensive essay questions examining major critical movements, theorists, and conceptual paradigms.

1. Formalism, Structuralism & Semiotics

1. What is Formalism? Differentiate defamiliarization from foregrounding, using examples from the texts you have read. [50]
2. Explain Roland Barthes's concept of "myth" and Northrop Frye's idea of "Archetype" by illustrating from any text of your choice. [50]
3. What fundamental characteristics do New Criticism and Formalism share? How do they differ? Explain defamiliarization (Shklovsky) and foregrounding (Mayakovsky). [49]
4. Contrast the structuralist approach to literature with the New Critical approach to literature. Briefly explain Ferdinand de Saussure's theory of 'sign'. How does Roland Barthes apply the structuralist method to decode boxing and wrestling? [49]
5. What is formalism? Discuss, with examples, Shklovsky's notion and techniques of ostranenie. [47]
6. "Structuralism looks at the relationship between the various elements within the self-contained, well-organized structure of a text" in order to understand the meaning-making process. Discuss this statement by citing one of the structuralist thinkers that you have read. [47]
7. What do you understand by 'form' in formalism? Discuss the different phases of formalism. [46]
8. What is "close reading"? What does a Formalist critic do while reading a literary text? [44]

2. Marxist Literary Theory & Ideology

1. What is the relationship between modes of production and relations of production? What, according to Marx, leads to alienation? [50, 43]

2. According to Louis Althusser, "ideology interpellates the individual as subject." Elaborate. [50]
3. Explain Dialectical Materialism. How do Marxist literary critics relate social class to 'literariness'? How do the two main streams of Marxist criticism, "Engelsian" and "Leninist," differ? What are 'overdetermination' and 'relative autonomy'? [49]
4. Define ideology. How do ISA and RSA function in a society, and what role do they play in shaping individuals' identity? [48, 46, 44]
5. What is ideology? What does a Marxist critic do while reading a literary or cultural text? [42]

3. Psychoanalytic Criticism

1. How does Lacan conceptualize the Real, the Imaginary, and the Symbolic? Apply these concepts to any literary text of your choice. [50]
2. Define unconscious. Give an account of Lacanian three orders that develop the human psyche. [48]
3. How does Freud structure the human psyche? Discuss the ways the ego mobilizes against unacceptable or unconscious desires and makes defenses. [47]
4. What is defence mechanism? Discuss different types of Freudian defence mechanisms with examples if necessary. [44]
5. Define "the unconscious". What does a psychoanalytic critic do while reading a literary or cultural text? [43]
6. Discuss the linguistic phase of Lacanian psychoanalysis. How does this phase disillusion a child from its mirror phase? [42]

4. Feminist Literary Theory

1. How does Third Wave Feminism embrace diversity, difference and individualism? Discuss this with particular focus on any of the critical positions taken by the Third Wave feminists. [50, 47]
2. Compare and contrast black feminist criticism and postcolonial feminism. Explain and evaluate l'écriture féminine. What is 'Images of Women' criticism? [49]
3. What is feminism? Discuss any two French Feminists' contribution to feminism. [48]
4. What are the principal criticisms about the Second Wave of feminist movement? [44]
5. Discuss Hélène Cixous' position in identifying women not in terms of sexual difference, but in the light of a specifically women's language. [43]
6. Define Radical Feminism. Discuss briefly the critical position of Postcolonial Feminism in relation to First Wave Feminism. [42]

5. Post-structuralism, Deconstruction & Postmodernism

1. Discuss how Foucault examines the relationships between discourse and power in his works. [50]
2. Differentiate post-structuralism from structuralism. What is jouissance for Kristeva? Discuss deconstruction in brief. [49]
3. How and on what points does poststructuralism differ from structuralism? How does Derrida critique logocentrism? [48]
4. Define postmodernism. Discuss Lyotard and Baudrillard's contribution to the theorization of postmodernism. [48, 44]
5. With reference to Ihab Hassan's "Toward a Concept of Postmodernism" explain what postmodernism is. [47]
6. What is poststructuralism? Discuss the major premises and assumptions of poststructuralism. [46]
7. How is Saussurean signification system different from Derridean meaning-making process? [44, 42]
8. Deleuzian and Barthesian schools endorse pluralistic discourse and episteme. Justify. [43]
9. Pastiche and carnivalesque subvert hegemony. — Discuss. [43]
10. Give an account of Baudrillard's notion of the "precession of simulacra." [42]

6. Reader-Response, Cultural Theory & Postcolonialism

1. What is representation? Examine how the discursive approach to representation critiques and complements the semiotic approach to representation. [50]
2. What is Reception theory? Explain 'Horizons of expectations'. What are the pros and cons of reader-response criticism? Explain J.L. Austin's theory of 'speech acts'. [49]
3. What is reader-response criticism? Discuss any two of the reader-response theories. [48, 46]
4. What is representation? Discuss Hall's different approaches of representation. [48]
5. With reference to Rosenblatt and Iser's transactional reader-response theory, discuss, with examples, how the interaction between text and reader create meaning. [47]
6. Define critical theory. Discuss the major functions of critical theories with examples. [46]
7. Explicate the concept of 'culture' in Cultural Studies. [44, 43, 42]
8. Homi K. Bhabha's postcolonial criticism deploys a poststructuralist repertoire. Justify by discussing the notions of mimicry and ambivalence. [43]
9. Discuss the concept of culture mobilized by Cultural Studies. What is the use of doing Cultural Studies? [43]
10. Elucidate Stuart Hall's notion of cultural identity as a matter of both "being" and "becoming" in the context of diaspora. [42]
11. Cultural Studies views culture as a site of struggle and resistance. — Discuss. [42]

SECTION B: SHORT NOTES & CONCISE THEORETICAL CONCEPTS

Short analytical notes covering key terms, critical vocabulary, and theoretical distinctions.

Short Notes Collection

1. How does Chandra Talpade Mohanty critique Western feminist scholarship's construction of the 'Third World Woman'? [50, 49]
2. Why does Fairclough critique Foucault's discourse analysis? [50]
3. How do Kate Millett and Juliet Mitchell differ on Freud? [50]
4. How does 'pastiche' differ from 'parody'? Exemplify. [49, 47]
5. Relate 'repression' and 'sublimation' to Freudian 'unconscious'. Provide an example. [49]
6. Define 'discourse' and 'representation'. Exemplify how discourse shapes representation. [49]
7. How does Baudrillard use Disneyland as an example of 'hyperreality'? [49]
8. Deterritorialization and becoming (Deleuze) [49]
9. Mythos of autumn vs. mythos of spring (Northrop Frye) [48]
10. Popular culture [48, 42]
11. Id, ego and superego [48, 46]
12. Parapraxis (Freudian slip) [47]
13. Relationship between latent dream thoughts and manifest dream content [47]
14. Stuart Hall's concept of representation [46]
15. Foucault's power and knowledge [46]
16. Compulsory heterosexuality (Adrienne Rich) [46]
17. 'Baring the device' (Formalism) [44]

18. Cultural materialism [44, 42]
19. Androgynous mind (Virginia Woolf) [44]
20. Mimicry (Homi Bhabha) [44]
21. Ostranenie (Defamiliarization) [43]
22. Metaphysics of presence (Derrida) [43]
23. Paradigm and syntagm (Saussure) [43]
24. Archetypal criticism [43]
25. Grand narrative (Lyotard) [43]
26. Ambivalence (Bhabha) [42]
27. Écriture féminine (Cixous) [42]
28. Foregrounding [42]

SECTION C: APPLIED CRITICAL READINGS & CULTURAL TEXT ANALYSIS

Practical application of critical theories to literary texts, poems, cultural artifacts, images, and advertisements.

Discourse Analysis of Children's Literature: Dick and Jane in *The Bluest Eye* [48]

Task: Read the Dick and Jane primer from Toni Morrison's *The Bluest Eye*:

"Here is the house. It is green and white. It has a red door. It is very pretty. Here is the family. Mother, Father, Dick, and Jane live in the green-and-white house. They are very happy. See Jane. She has a red dress. She wants to play... See Father. He is big and strong. Father, will you play with Jane? Father is smiling. Smile, Father, smile..."

Questions:

- a) How does the language used in the primer reinforce traditional gender roles and family dynamics?
- b) How does Morrison deconstruct this dominant cultural narrative through Pecola's reality?

Marxist Reading: Characterization of Willy Loman in *Death of a Salesman* [47]

Attempt a short Marxist reading of the characterization of Willy Loman from Arthur Miller's *Death of a Salesman*, focusing on alienation, commodity fetishism, and false consciousness.

Poststructuralist Reading: Robert Frost's "Fire and Ice" [47]

Offer a poststructuralist / deconstructive reading of Frost's poem "Fire and Ice", exploring how the binary oppositions break down into aporia:

*"Some say the world will end in fire,
Some say in ice.
From what I've tasted of desire
I hold with those who favor fire.
But if it had to perish twice,
I think I know enough of hate
To say that for destruction ice
Is also great
And would suffice."*

Semiological Reading: Environmental Campaign Visual Signification [47]

With reference to Roland Barthes' process of signification (*Mythologies*: signifier, signified, and second-order mythological meaning), provide a semiological reading of the visual slogan *"ENSURE ENVIRONMENT / Go Green / REDUCE SAVE / GLOBAL WARMING"*.

Psychoanalytic & Deconstructive Readings [46]

- a) Focusing on Freud's idea of Oedipus Complex, offer a psychoanalytic reading of D.H. Lawrence's *Sons and Lovers*.
- b) Offer a deconstructive reading of T.S. Eliot's "The Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock" focusing on hesitation, deferral, and fractured identity.
- c) Do you consider John Cage's music composition 4'33" as postmodern? Explain.

Black Feminist Reading: Audre Lorde's "A Woman Speaks" [44]

Offer a Black Feminist reading of the poem "A Woman Speaks" by Audre Lorde. How does this poem challenge cultural stereotypes about women of colour and reassert Black identity?

"Moon marked and touched by sun / my magic is unwritten / but when the sea turns back / it will leave my shape behind... I am / woman / and not white."

Cultural Reading: Fashion Brand Advertisement & Music Excerpt [43, 42]

- a) **Marxist Reading:** Analyze Barbara Kruger's photographic slogan "*I shop therefore I am*" in the context of consumer capitalism and identity commodification. [44]
- b) **Black Feminist Reading:** Offer a Black feminist reading of Beyoncé's song excerpt "*Pretty Hurts*" (analyzing pageant culture, eurocentric beauty standards, and body surveillance). [42]